

Mia and the little treasure that grew when shared

Hidden treasure story • 3-4 years old



Part 1

Mia was three. She had curly hair and bright shoes that went tap-tap on the path.

One sunny morning, Mia found a tiny bottle under the garden bench. It smelled like lemons and warm grass. Inside was a rolled-up paper.

“Mommy, look!” Mia said.

Mommy smiled. “A message?”

Mia opened it very carefully. The paper felt crisp, like a dry leaf. On it was a simple map with a red X. There were also three pictures: a shiny spoon, a smooth stone, and a little scale. Under the pictures it said, in big friendly letters:

WEIGH TWO THINGS. FIND THE KEY. SHARE THE TREASURE.

Mia’s eyes got wide. “Treasure!”

“Treasure hunts are for brave helpers,” Mommy said. “Are you a brave helper?”

Mia stood tall. “I am brave.”

And off they went. Mia held the map. It smelled a bit like old paper and sweet dust. The air was soft. Birds sang “tweet-tweet.” A breeze brushed Mia’s cheeks.

They walked to the apple tree first, because the map showed an apple tree like a green cloud.

Under the apple tree, Mia saw a little wooden box. It had a tiny door. The door was closed with a ribbon.

Mia touched the ribbon. It felt silky. "Open?"

Mommy pointed to the map. "It says we have to weigh two things to find the key."

Mia nodded. "Weigh."

They looked around. On the grass sat a small toy scale, like the one in Mia's play kitchen. It was painted yellow and blue. It had two little bowls that could hold things.

Mia put her hands on it. "Hello, scale."

Mommy laughed softly. "Hello, scale."

Near the scale was a shiny spoon, just like the picture. It sparkled in the sun. Mia picked it up. It was cool and smooth. Nearby was a round stone, gray and gentle, like a tiny moon.

Mia placed the spoon in one bowl. "Spoon."

Then she placed the stone in the other bowl. "Stone."

The scale tipped down on the stone side. The stone was heavier.

Mia leaned close. She listened. The scale made a tiny creak, like a sleepy door.

Mommy whispered, "What do you think we do next?"

Mia thought hard. Her tongue peeked out a little, the way it did when she built tall blocks.

"Maybe... we need a heavier spoon?" Mia said.

Mommy's eyes shone. "Smart thinking. Let's look."

They searched together. Mia looked under leaves that smelled like green tea. Mommy looked near the tree roots. Mia's fingers found something cold again.

"A bigger spoon!" Mia said.

It was a wooden spoon, bigger and thick. It smelled like soup.

Mia put the wooden spoon in the bowl. "Big spoon."

Now the spoon side went down. The scale tipped, and from under the scale popped a little brass key with a happy clink.

Mia clapped. "Key! Key!"

Mommy hugged her. "You did it. You were brave, smart, and patient."

Mia held the key. It felt warm in her palm. "Open box now?"

"Yes," Mommy said. "Let's open it gently."

Part 2

Mia slid the key into the tiny lock. Click.

The ribbon loosened like it was sighing. The little door opened.

Inside, there was not gold. Not jewels. Not even a pirate hat.

Inside was a new note and a small cloth bag with a string.

Mia sniffed the bag. It smelled like cinnamon.

She opened the note. Mommy read it aloud in a soft, mystery voice:

“WELL DONE, LITTLE HELPER.

FOLLOW THE RED DOTS.

LISTEN FOR THE WATER.

THE TREASURE LIKES KIND HANDS.”

Mia looked down. On the path were tiny red dots, painted like ladybugs. Dot, dot, dot. They led away from the apple tree.

Mia walked along them. Tap-tap, tap-tap. Mommy walked beside her. The garden sounded friendly. Bees went “bzz.” Leaves went “shh-shh.”

Soon Mia heard a new sound. “Plip... plip... plip...”

“Water,” Mia whispered.

They came to a small fountain with clear water dancing in a round bowl. It smelled fresh, like rain.

By the fountain sat a little wooden bench. Under the bench was a flat stone, smooth like soap. Mia lifted it with both hands. It was heavy, but Mia was sturdy.

Under the stone was a tiny door in the ground. A small metal handle waited like it was holding its breath.

Mia’s heart went thump-thump, but it felt like a happy thump. “Treasure is here,” she said.

Mommy crouched. “You can do this. I’m right here.”

Mia pulled the handle. The door opened with a quiet “creeeak,” not scary, just sleepy.

Inside was a small box with a heart painted on it. The box had no lock. It had a sign that said:

OPEN WITH A FRIEND.

Mia looked at Mommy. "Friend?"

Mommy nodded. "We can open it together."

Mia put one hand on the lid. Mommy put her hand on top of Mia's hand. The lid felt cool and a little dusty.

Together they lifted.

Inside were tiny treasures: smooth shells that smelled like the sea, a little bell that went "ding," a soft scarf in bright colors, and a small packet of shiny stickers shaped like stars. There was also a note that said:

THIS TREASURE GROWS WHEN YOU SHARE.

Mia's eyes sparkled. "Stars!"

Mommy pointed to the cloth bag. "Maybe the bag is for sharing."

Mia held the bag and nodded very seriously. "Share."

Just then, they heard steps on the path. Tap-tap, tap-tap, but not Mia's shoes. It was Grandma, coming with a basket of muffins. The muffins smelled sweet and warm.

Grandma waved. "Hello, my little sunshine."

Mia ran to her, careful not to trip. "Grandma! Treasure!"

Grandma sat on the bench. "Oh! A treasure hunt?"

Mia showed the shells and the bell. She rang it gently. “Ding!”

Grandma laughed. “What a lovely sound.”

Mia thought of the note. She took a star sticker and placed it on Grandma’s hand.

“For you,” Mia said.

Grandma’s eyes softened. “Thank you. That is very kind.”

Mia gave Mommy a sticker too. Then Mia looked around. A little boy from next door, Leo, was walking by with his toy truck. He looked curious.

Mia waved. “Leo! Want star?”

Leo smiled shyly. “Yes, please.”

Mia peeled another sticker and put it on his truck. “Now truck has star.”

Leo giggled. “My truck is fancy!”

Mia placed shells into the cinnamon bag. “We can share shells too,” she said. “One for Grandma. One for Leo. One for Mommy.”

Mommy kissed Mia’s forehead. “Your treasure is your big heart.”

Mia looked back at the open box. It was still full of lovely things. It did not look smaller. It looked brighter.

They sat by the fountain and ate muffins. The water went “plip-plip,” like gentle claps. The scarf felt soft on Mia’s lap. The sun warmed their backs.

Mia leaned against Mommy. “More treasure later?”

Mommy whispered, “Any time you help and share, you make treasure.”

Mia smiled, sleepy and happy. “I am brave helper.”

“Yes,” Mommy said. “You are.”

The quiz: did you understand the story well?

1) Who found the tiny bottle in the garden?

- Mia
- Mommy
- Grandma
- Leo

2) What did Mia and Mommy do to make the key appear?

- Weigh two things
- Sing a song
- Run to the tree
- Paint the box

3) What sound did the little bell make?

- Ding
- Moo
- Meow
- Beep

4) What did Mia do with the treasures?

- Share with friends
- Keep all
- Hide them
- Throw them away

Correct answers:

1) Mia 2) Weigh two things 3) Ding 4) Share with friends

Glossary: complicated words in the story

Brass key: A small metal key that is yellow and shiny.

Fountain: A place where water comes up and falls in a bowl.

Cinnamon: A warm brown spice that smells sweet and spicy.

Patient: Calm and waiting without getting upset.

Silky: Very smooth and soft like a kitten's fur.

Scale: A tool that tells which thing is heavier.

Handle: A part you pull or hold to open something.

Clink: A short, bright sound of metal touching metal.

Treasure: Special things that make people very happy.

Sighing: A soft breath that sounds like someone is gentle or tired.